expressed reservations about this plan. Nehru and Patel contemplated a settlement based on the ‘existing military situation’, which would have meant the effective partitioning of Jammu and Kashmir, an option that was also rejected by Pakistan. [22] With India receiving assurances that a plebiscite would only be carried out if Pakistan kept its end of the bargain (i.e. the removal of Pakistani forces), a ceasefire was agreed in December 1948. The end of the first India–Pakistan War resulted in an open-ended and less-than-satisfactory situation: the continued presence of irregular forces in Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir (PoK), nascent calls for Kashmiri independence by Sheikh Abdullah as a compromise, the attempted shifting of the goalposts for demilitarization by UN mediators, and a special status for Jammu and Kashmir in the Indian Constitution. [23]

Beyond these three princely states, the process of Independence and Partition threw up some other ambiguities. One example was the state of Kalat, in today’s Pakistani province of Balochistan, whose status in British India was slightly more autonomous than that of most princely states. Under pressure to join Pakistan, the Khan of Kalat wrote to India to discuss the possibility of accession in January 1948, but his entreaties were refused. India lacked a strong legal or practical basis to stake a claim. [24] The status of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands—which the British had used as a penal colony, and which had been occupied by Japan during World War II—was also in question. Pakistan pressed claims to this territory based on its proximity to East Bengal. The islands only became a part of India in 1950 and are now of considerable strategic significance. [25]

With the Communist Party coming to power in China in 1949 and its annexation of Tibet in 1950–1951, India also felt the need to reinforce relations with buffer states in the Himalayas. With Nepal, Bhutan, and Sikkim, India negotiated new treaties. Nepal, the most autonomous of the three, agreed to a Treaty of Peace and Friendship in 1950 that facilitated the flow of people and goods and allowed for close cooperation on defence, and foreign relations. After signing a standstill agreement upon Indian independence, Bhutan negotiated a Treaty of Peace and Friendship in 1949 that allowed India to guide the country’s external relations. Meanwhile, a